





THE MIX (From left) Rekha Roddwittiya's 'River of Dreams'; Paritosh Sen's 'Untitled (isabelle series)'; Akbar Padamsee's 'Untitled'; K.S. Kulkarni's 'Untitled'

EXHIBITION

Cultural Catalyst

The DAG Delhi exhibition, ***India's Rockefeller Artists***, features works by the grant's beneficiaries



The history of modernity in art, literature, music et al is inextricable from the history of philanthropic grants. To break free from convention, artists require all the support—financial and otherwise—they can get. Studying the history of grants, therefore, provides a valuable window into the evolution of art itself. DAG Delhi's ongoing exhibition, *India's Rockefeller Artists*, focuses on some of the beneficiaries of such an endowment.

Curated by Kishore Singh, head of exhibitions and publications at DAG, the exhibition includes works by artists and sculptors who travelled to America as awardees of the JDR 3rd Fund, named after John D. Rockefeller III (1906-1978). Following Rockefeller's death, the grants were continued under the Asian Cultural Council. The awardees featured in this exhibition include artists such as S.H. Raza, V.S. Gaitonde, Ram Kumar, K.G. Subramanyan, Satish Gujral and Jyoti Bhatt.

DAG Delhi's exhibition, **INDIA'S ROCKEFELLER ARTISTS**, is on till October 12 in the national capital

About the impact of the JDR 3rd Fund, Singh says, "Apart from the generous financial support the artists received, they were invited to important museum previews and openings, provided support in getting interviews with curators, museum directors, gallery heads, and even got seats to concerts, theatre opening nights and other such events—placing them in the centre of New York's art and culture scene. The benefit was immense in terms of visibility and contacts and relationships."

You can see very different artistic journeys unfolding across the individual sections. Ram Kumar's work becomes much less figurative after his New York years, whereas Tyeb Mehta's work moves in the opposite direction. Bhupen Khakhar went to New York in the 1980s after JDR's death, when the Fund was renamed the Asian Cultural Council. Khakhar's mother had also recently passed away. His work post-1980 incorporates the gay experience "unapologetically into everyday life", says Singh. "His paintings are never about fear—of sex, of being found out or of its repercussions."

Interestingly, Khakhar's American travels had happened following a decade's break where no artist had availed of the grant because of suspicions surrounding the CIA. Several Asian countries, including India, had, at the time, expressed fears that the CIA had embedded its assets within artistic circles in foreign countries—the so-called "culture vulture" gambit. Political quibbles aside, the hiatus in the grant temporarily halted what this exhibition confirms—a lively, imaginative cultural exchange between India and America. *India's Rockefeller Artists* provides some great insights into the way Indo-American encounters influenced the trajectory of modernity in Indian art. ■

–Aditya Mani Jha